

DIGITALAIKART

The WhatsApp Business AI Playbook

Indian SMB Edition

Set up Meta's free Business AI on WhatsApp, train it to sell while you sleep, and know exactly when to upgrade to the API.

A practical, verified setup guide for Indian shop owners, clinic managers, coaches, sellers and service businesses.

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How to use this playbook. Read Chapters 1-3 once, then work through Chapter 4 with a pen - it becomes the brain of your AI. Chapters 6-7 are for later, when your message volume grows. Everything in here was verified against Meta's official documentation, WhatsApp Help Center and industry data current as of September 2026.

Why Your Business Needs AI on WhatsApp Right Now

If you run a shop, clinic, coaching class, boutique, or any small business in India, your customers are already on WhatsApp - and most of them message you before they ever call. India has over 500 million WhatsApp users, the largest market in the world, and a Kantar study found that 91% of online adults in India chat with a business every week. Around 97% of Indian MSMEs already use WhatsApp for business communication.

The problem is not messages. The problem is 11:40 p.m. messages. “kitne ka hai?”, “delivery kab tak hoga?”, “kal khula hai kya?” - questions that arrive after your shop shuts, go unanswered till morning, and by then the customer has bought from someone who replied in two minutes. WhatsApp messages in India see open rates of 90-98%, compared to roughly 18-25% for email - which means every unanswered message was almost certainly read... by your competitor's reply instead.

What changed in 2026. In May 2026, Meta launched Business AI on WhatsApp for small businesses in India. It works inside the free WhatsApp Business app, requires no coding and no third-party tools, understands all native Indian languages, and can answer customer queries 24/7, recommend products, capture leads and book appointments. Meta has also announced that Business AI will soon accept UPI payments directly inside the chat.

(Source: Meta newsroom announcement, May 2026; Kantar 2025; PayNearby-Zinnov MSME Digital Index 2024; Nurotech industry data 2026.)

What real Indian businesses saw

Two Indian small businesses Meta featured at launch show what is possible:

“We were losing leads that came in late at night, and now with 24/7 support, our conversion rate has skyrocketed to 80-90%. Setting up Business AI on WhatsApp was incredibly simple - no coding, no complex third-party software. I just uploaded our product catalog and documents, and the AI learned the details and tone of my business.”

- Tuba Siddiqui, Co-founder, Soil Concept (plant-based personal care brand, now serving 15,000+ customers)

“Within a few hours, Business AI learned everything about my business and was able to reply to customers on my behalf, exactly how I would. It helps me close 6-7 orders daily through queries handled by the AI, and I've seen a 40% increase in sales.”

- Gunveen Kaur, Founder, The Purple Sunset (personalised gifting business that was handling 60-70 customer queries a day)

A 40% lift in sales and recovered after-hours leads, from a free feature inside an app you already use. That is the opportunity this playbook walks you through - without paying a

developer, an agency, or a monthly platform fee to start.

The Free Path: Business AI Inside the WhatsApp Business App

Business AI (called “Meta Business Agent” in Meta's developer documentation) is built directly into the WhatsApp Business app. It learns from your business profile, your catalogue, your website and documents you give it, then replies to customers in your tone. You stay in control: you can jump into any conversation, adjust the AI, or switch it off entirely at any time.

Step 1 - Get the foundation right first (30 minutes)

The AI can only be as good as the information it starts from. Before you switch anything on, complete these in the WhatsApp Business app:

- Use a dedicated business number, not your personal one. A separate SIM or virtual number costs a little and saves a lot of confusion later.
- Complete every field of your business profile: legal/display name, category, description, address, hours, website, email. A half-filled profile produces vague answers like “please contact us for details” - which defeats the purpose.
- Build your catalogue: add products or services with names, prices in rupees and clear descriptions. Even a clinic or CA firm should list services as items with pricing, so the AI can quote confidently instead of dodging.
- Update the app to the latest version - the feature is still rolling out in waves, so if you don't see it yet, re-check after updating.

Step 2 - Turn on your Business AI (10 minutes)

Open the WhatsApp Business app, go to the Tools tab and select “Your Business AI” (on some versions it appears as “AI agent”). Follow the guided steps: you may be asked to scan a QR code with your phone and accept the terms. Meta's eligibility rules apply to businesses in India - most ordinary retail, services, education and commerce businesses qualify. (Note: on the paid API tier, Meta excludes certain verticals - finance, government, health, alcohol, gambling, over-the-counter drugs and matrimony services.)

Step 3 - Choose when the AI replies

From the Tools tab, open Your Business AI > AI replies and pick the mode that fits your comfort level:

AI replies mode	What it does
All new 1-1 chats	The AI responds to every new chat between your business and a customer.

AI replies mode	What it does
1-1 chats except with contacts	The AI skips chats from people saved in your contacts - friends and regulars always reach you.
1-1 chats from ads	The AI only handles chats that start when someone clicks your Facebook or Instagram ad - great for capturing ad leads after hours.
Paused for new chats but learning	The AI stays silent but keeps studying incoming chats so it is ready when you switch it on. Recommended for the first week.

(Source: WhatsApp Help Center - "How to set up Meta Business Agent"; Meta developer documentation.)

Two rules worth knowing. (1) If you switch the AI on in a chat where you are already mid-conversation with a customer, it will not reply to that customer until the chat has been inactive for seven days - unless you tap "Restart AI replies in this chat". (2) You can also enable the AI chat-by-chat: open a chat, tap the menu, choose AI replies, and turn it on.

Total time so far: under an hour. Total cost: zero. This alone puts a polite, well-informed, all-languages assistant on your business number every night and every weekend.

Train It Well: The Step 90% of Owners Rush

Switching the AI on is easy - which is exactly why so many owners stop there and then complain that “the bot doesn't know anything”. The single biggest performance lever is how thoroughly you train it.

What the data says

MyOperator analysed 262 AI agents run by 91 Indian businesses over 12 months, processing 307,925 WhatsApp messages. Three findings stand out:

- The average AI agent was trained with only about 5,700 characters of instructions - roughly 28% of the 20,000-character training capacity. The top performers training space with complete knowledge bases, specific instructions, edge cases and escalation logic.
- The best businesses ran three or more specialist agents - one each for sales inquiries, support, bookings, lead qualification - rather than one bot trying to do everything. The single best specialist agent handled over 68,900 messages.
- Configuration quality, not the AI model or the plan size, determined performance. Lower-tier plans performed like enterprise deployments when thoroughly configured.

(Source: MyOperator platform data on 262 WhatsApp AI agents, 2026.)

How to feed your AI

Your Business AI learns from three places. First, what already exists: your profile, catalogue and website. Second, documents, images and links you give it - upload your price list, policies, menu, or service brochure. Third, the FAQs and instructions you write directly (Chapter 4 gives you the worksheet).

Write FAQs the way customers actually type. Not “What are your operating hours?” but “kitne baje tak khula rehta hai?”, “same day delivery hoti hai kya?”, “Sunday bhi open hai kya?”. Aim for 15 to 25 real questions in the exact words, spellings and Hinglish mix your customers use. The AI's language handling covers all native Indian languages - your job is making sure the knowledge is there in the first place.

Think of training like onboarding a new shop assistant. You would not hand a new hire the keys and disappear; you would explain the products, the prices, what to say when something is out of stock, and when to call you. Same here - except this assistant works every hour you don't.

The Knowledge Worksheet (Fill It In)

This chapter is the heart of the playbook. Print it or copy it into a notes app and fill every blank before you switch the AI from “paused” to active. The more specifically you fill it, the fewer wrong answers your AI will give - remember, top-performing agents use their full training capacity, average ones use about a quarter of it.

Section A - Business facts the AI must know

Fill in	Your answer
What exactly do you sell, in one sentence?	_____
Top 5 products/services + prices	1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____ 4. _____ 5. _____
Open days & timings	_____
Service area / delivery radius	_____
Delivery time & charges	_____
Payment methods accepted (UPI, COD, cards)	_____
Return / exchange / refund policy	_____
Languages to reply in	_____
Anything you NEVER say (discount promises, medical claims, etc.)	_____

Section B - Tone and behaviour rules

Write these as instructions. Sample set you can adapt (fill in your brackets):

- Always reply in the language the customer writes in - Hindi, English, Hinglish or [your regional language].
- Be warm and brief. 2-4 sentences per reply. No long paragraphs.
- Quote prices exactly as in the catalogue - never invent a discount or a price.
- If a product is out of stock, say so honestly and offer [alternative].
- Never make promises about delivery dates, warranty or [sensitive topic] - say the owner will confirm.
- Collect name and phone number before answering detailed custom-order questions.

Section C - The FAQ bank (15-25 entries)

Write each question exactly as a customer would type it, then the ideal short answer.

Starter set:

Customer asks (their words)	Ideal short answer
kitne ka hai?	Price + what's included + link to catalogue item
delivery available hai mera area me?	Yes/no + area + time + charges
COD hai kya?	Payment options + how to order
kal khula rehta hai?	Exact timings for that day
discount mil jayega bulk me?	Escalate to owner - never promise
order kaise karu?	3-step ordering instructions
[Your most common query]	[Your best answer]

Section D - Handoff rules

Decide in writing when the AI must hand over to a human, for example: refund requests, complaints, bulk/corporate orders, anything involving money disputes, or a customer who says “manager se baat karo” twice. Also set your away message: hours, and an honest promise like “we'll reply by 10 a.m.” for the gaps.

The 20-Minute Test Script

Before you let the AI face real customers, test it the way an auditor would. Send these from a second phone or a family member's number, in the languages your customers actually use:

1. Price question: “XYZ ka rate kya hai?” - Is the price exact, with the right product included?
2. Mixed-language question: “Aaj order karu toh kal mil jayega? delivery charge kitna lagega?” - Does it handle Hinglish naturally?
3. Out-of-stock item: ask about something you don't sell. Does it say so honestly instead of inventing an answer?
4. Discount trap: “bhai thoda discount de do, wholesale rate lagao.” Does it hold the line politely?
5. Edge case: a two-line question with three things bundled - price, delivery and timing. Does it answer all three?
6. Escalation: “refund chahiye, manager se baat karo.” Does it hand off to you instead of arguing?
7. Off-topic: “weather kaisa hai aaj?” Does it steer back to business politely?
8. Late-night timing: send one at 11:30 p.m. Does the reply come instantly and sound like you?

The 50-conversation soft launch. Even after the tests pass, don't announce anything. Let the AI run quietly for a few days, then read through the first 50 real conversations. Every place the AI was vague, wrong or awkward is a line to add to your worksheet from Chapter 4. Fix, re-test, repeat. This one habit separates businesses that get 40% more sales from businesses that say “AI doesn't work”.

Keep a small note on your phone: every time a customer asks something the AI got wrong, note it. Once a week, feed the corrected answers back in. That's the whole maintenance routine.

When to Upgrade to the WhatsApp Business API

The free in-app Business AI is genuinely enough for most solo owners. But at some volume, you will outgrow it. These are the signals that it's time for the WhatsApp Business Platform (the Cloud API):

- You're getting more than 40-50 meaningful queries a day and one phone can't keep up.
- You have a team that needs to share one business number with proper routing.
- Customers want to complete orders and pay inside the chat, not just ask questions.
- The bot needs live stock, order status, or customer history from your systems.
- You want to send promotional or transactional broadcasts at scale (with opt-in).
- You need regional-language voice support or deep CRM integration.

App vs API at a glance

What matters	Free app + Business AI	Business API (via a provider)
Cost	Free	Provider fee from about ₹999/month plus Meta's message charges
Who sets it up	You, in under an hour	You or a partner; 1-4 weeks end to end
Team on one number	Limited	Multiple agents with routing
Orders & payments in chat	Manual	Automated flows, UPI collection
CRM / inventory integration	No	Yes
Bulk messaging	No	Yes, with approved templates and opt-in
Best for	Solo owner, single location	Growing business, 6+ team members

(Costs as reported by Indian BSP listings, September 2026.)

Don't upgrade early. A managed API setup typically costs ₹6,000-15,000 a month once AI and CRM sync are included. If you're handling a few hundred conversations a month with the free app, that money is better spent elsewhere. Upgrade when the workload genuinely outgrows the free tier - not because a vendor's salesman said so.

The API Path: BSPs, Costs and Setup

The WhatsApp Business API isn't an app you download - you reach it through Meta directly or, more practically, through an official Business Solution Provider (BSP). Indian BSP plans start around ₹999 per month (Interakt, AiSensy) to ₹2,499 (Wati, Gallabox), plus Meta's own message charges. A BSP handles the technical plumbing, and good ones also manage green-tick verification, template approvals and compliance for you.

The setup, step by step

1. Create and verify your Meta Business account. You'll need your legal business name, address and website. Verification is smoother with a GST certificate, Certificate of Incorporation, or Udyam (MSME) registration, plus a matching utility bill or bank statement. You don't strictly need GST - but formal documents make verification far faster.
2. Choose your number carefully. Once a number moves to the API it cannot be used in the regular app. Many businesses pick a fresh number to protect the owner's personal line.
3. Apply for your display name (and green tick if you want it). The green verified badge is a separate approval based on notability - not everyone gets it, and that's fine.
4. Submit message templates. Any message sent outside a 24-hour customer-initiated window must use a pre-approved template - order confirmations, shipping updates, appointment reminders. Submit early; approvals can take from minutes to a couple of days.
5. Configure your AI or chatbot flow: business information, products, prices, FAQs, policies, timings, and fallback rules for human handoff. (Reuse your Chapter 4 worksheet - it works here too.)
6. Connect catalogue and CRM so leads land somewhere your team actually checks - even a Google Sheet beats nothing.
7. Set team routing: by language, product or region - useful in India where customer expectations vary by city.
8. Test end to end, then soft launch. Watch the first 50 real conversations before announcing anything.
9. Expect 7-14 days end to end for a straightforward business with documents in order - most of it is Meta's verification and template approvals, not the build.

What Meta actually charges (verified July 2026)

Meta's official pricing model, effective since July 1, 2025, charges businesses per delivered template message, with rates depending on the template's category and the recipient's country. The parts that matter to an Indian SMB:

Message type	Charge
Customer messages you (opens the 24-hour customer service window)	Free - user-to-business messages are never charged
Your normal replies within an open customer service window (text, images, etc.)	Free since November 1, 2024
Utility templates sent in response to a user, within an open service window	Free since July 1, 2025
Everything within a free entry point window (e.g. a customer clicks your ad or Click-to-WhatsApp link)	Free for 72 hours - including template messages
Marketing templates (promotions, offers)	Charged per delivered message; rates vary by category and country
Authentication templates (OTPs)	Charged per delivered message; volume tiers can lower the rate

(Source: Meta for Developers - "Pricing on the WhatsApp Business Platform", updated July 1, 2026. Note: Meta has announced further pricing updates for service and utility messages rolling out on August 1 and October 1, 2026 - check Meta's pricing page before finalising a budget.)

In plain words: answering customers who message you is free. You pay when you push marketing or transactional templates to people. So a support-and-sales AI on inbound chats costs you almost nothing in Meta charges - the bulk of your cost is the BSP platform fee.

Stay Legal: DPDP Basics for Chat Businesses

India's Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023 became enforceable in 2025-26 and applies to the customer data flowing through your WhatsApp chats - names, numbers, addresses, order history. Penalties for serious non-compliance can reach ₹250 crore, and small businesses are not exempt. You don't need a lawyer to stay on the right side of four basic rules:

1. Take real consent before messaging customers for marketing. A phone number scribbled at your counter or scraped from a delivery sheet is not valid consent. Ask in chat, on a form, or via a checkbox - and keep proof.
2. Never buy or scrape contact lists and blast them. It's the fastest route to a Meta ban and a data-protection problem at the same time.
3. Collect only what you need for the order, use it only for what you said you'd use it for, and delete it when the customer asks.
4. Keep customer data inside tools you control - your WhatsApp, your BSP account, your CRM. Don't forward customer lists to random agencies.

(This is practical orientation, not legal advice - for your specific situation, consult a professional.)

The 14-Day Rollout Plan

Everything from this playbook, arranged into two weeks of about 30-60 minutes a day. Tick as you go.

Day	What you do	Time
1	Get a dedicated business number if you don't have one. Install/verify WhatsApp Business app.	45 min
2	Complete your business profile 100% - every field.	30 min
3	Build your catalogue: products/services, rupee prices, descriptions.	60 min
4	Fill in the Chapter 4 Knowledge Worksheet (Sections A-B).	60 min
5	Write your FAQ bank - 15 to 25 questions in customers' words.	60 min
6	Turn on Business AI in "paused but learning" mode. Let it study.	15 min
7	Run the 20-minute test script. Fix what fails. Repeat.	30 min
8	Switch to "All new 1-1 chats" (or ads-only) mode. Say nothing publicly yet.	10 min
9	Read the first real conversations. Note every weak answer.	30 min
10	Update the AI with corrections from real chats.	30 min
11	Tell regulars and add "message us on WhatsApp anytime" to your shop board, bills, Instagram bio.	30 min
12	Keep reading chats; add one more FAQ cluster you discovered.	30 min
13	Set your weekly review habit (Chapter 10) - calendar reminder, same day, same time.	15 min
14	Score week one: after-hours queries answered, leads captured, sales closed via AI. Decide if you're near the Chapter 6 upgrade signals.	45 min

The Weekly Review Habit

A WhatsApp AI is not a one-time setup - it's a staff member that improves every time you brief it. Block 30 minutes, same day every week, and run this loop:

1. Read the logs. Scan the week's AI conversations. Every vague or wrong answer = one line to fix in your knowledge base.
2. Count the three numbers. Queries answered after hours, leads captured, orders or bookings closed through AI-handled chats.
3. Check the handoffs. Did escalations reach you quickly? Any customer frustrated by bot loops? (A bot that never offers a human destroys trust fast.)
4. Feed it back. Update FAQs, prices, and policies - especially before festive season, price changes or new launches.
5. Watch the upgrade signals. Consistently above 40-50 meaningful queries a day? Start Chapter 6.

Businesses that run this loop weekly are the ones converting midnight enquiries into morning orders - like the gifting business closing 6-7 orders a day through AI-handled chats, or the plant-care brand whose conversion climbed to 80-90% once no lead went cold. The AI is free; the habit is what you're paying for when you buy a playbook instead of guessing.

Budget Planner Worksheet

Fill this in before committing to any paid setup - so a provider's pitch never surprises you.

Line item	Typical range (India, Sep 2026)	Your number
WhatsApp Business app + Business AI	₹0 (free)	₹_____
BSP platform fee (Interakt / AiSensy)	from ₹999/month	₹_____
BSP platform fee (Wati / Gallabox)	from ₹2,499/month	₹_____
Managed BSP with AI agent (growing SMB)	₹6,000-15,000/month	₹_____
One-time chatbot build (simple FAQ, via agency)	₹15,000-30,000	₹_____
Meta message charges - replies to customers	₹0 within the service window	₹_____
Meta message charges - marketing templates	Per delivered message; check Meta's current rates	₹_____
Staff time saved (hours x hourly cost)	_____ hrs x ₹_____	₹_____
Extra sales needed to break even	(total monthly cost) / (avg order value)	_____ orders

(Ranges as reported by Indian BSP and industry listings, September 2026. Verify current rates with each provider before signing.)

Reality check from real deployments. A diagnostics lab that deployed a 12-flow WhatsApp bot reported 40% more booked slots, ₹18,000/month saved in staff time against a ₹9,500/month running cost. A coaching institute's lead qualification bot lifted lead-to-demo conversion from 18% to 31%. The economics work when the configuration is thorough - which is what Chapters 4 and 5 give you.

Quick Reference Card

The whole playbook on one page. Stick it near your billing counter.

START (Day 1, cost ₹0)

Dedicated number → complete profile → build catalogue → Tools tab → Your Business AI → follow guided steps.

TRAIN (the part everyone skips)

Full worksheet (Ch.4): facts + tone rules + 15-25 FAQs in customers' words + handoff rules. Top agents use their full training capacity; average ones use 28%.

TEST before trusting

Price question → Hinglish multi-part question → out-of-stock trap → discount trap → escalation → off-topic. Then 50 real conversations before announcing.

REVIEW weekly

Read logs → fix weak answers → count after-hours saves, leads, sales → check escalation speed.

UPGRADE only when

40-50+ meaningful queries/day · team needs one number · orders/payments in chat · live stock or CRM sync · broadcasts with opt-in.

PAY (only) for

BSP from ₹999/mo · marketing templates per message · replying to customers who message you: ₹0.

NEVER

Scraped lists · unapproved bulk blasts · promises the AI invented · sharing customer data with random tools.

12 Copy-Paste Message Templates

These are for YOU and your staff to use in chats the AI hands over - and as away/greeting messages in the app. Copy, fill the brackets, send. Written in the short, warm style Indian customers expect on WhatsApp.

1. Away message (Business hours setting)

Namaste! We're closed right now. Our team replies between [10 a.m. - 8 p.m.].
Leave your message here and we'll reply first thing - nothing gets missed.

2. Greeting message (new customer)

Hi! Welcome to [Business Name] Thanks for reaching out. Ask us about products, prices or delivery - we usually reply within minutes.

3. Price enquiry with lead capture

Hi! [Product] is ₹[price] - [what's included]. We currently have [colour/size] in stock. Shall I reserve one for you? Just share your name and area and I'll check the fastest delivery slot.

4. Order confirmation

Order confirmed [Item] x [qty] - ₹[amount]. We'll share the tracking details here as soon as it ships. Thank you for shopping with [Business Name]!

5. Delivery delay apology

Quick update: your order is taking [1 extra day] because [reason, honestly]. We're sorry - it will reach you by [date]. If that doesn't work for you, reply here and we'll sort it out.

6. Out of stock, with alternative

That one just went out of stock But [alternative] is very close in quality and actually ₹[price] cheaper. Want me to send photos?

7. Payment reminder (DPDP-safe)

Hi [Name], gentle reminder for order #[number] - ₹[amount] is pending. Here's our UPI: [ID]. If you've already paid, ignore this message and we'll confirm shortly

8. Review request after delivery

Hi [Name]! Did your order arrive okay? If you're happy with it, a quick review helps our small business a lot: [link]. Anything wrong, just tell us - we'll fix it.

9. Festive offer broadcast (opt-in only)

[Festival] special at [Business Name]: [offer in one line]. Valid till [date]. Reply STOP and we'll never send you offers. (Send broadcasts ONLY to customers who opted in - see Chapter 8.)

10. Cold lead follow-up (2 days later)

Hi [Name]! Just checking if you're still interested in [product]. Two were left this morning - happy to answer any question before you decide

11. Bulk / corporate enquiry escalation

Thanks for reaching out about a bulk order! My name is [Name] and I handle these personally. Please share quantity, delivery city and your deadline - I'll send a quote by [time] tomorrow.

12. Wrong number / spam, polite close

I think this message was meant for someone else No worries - have a great day! (And we'll be right here if you ever need [what you sell].)

Sources

All facts in this playbook were verified in September 2026 against: Meta newsroom (“Introducing Business AI on WhatsApp for Small Businesses in India”, May 2026), WhatsApp Help Center (Meta Business Agent setup and AI replies), Meta for Developers (WhatsApp Business Platform pricing, updated July 1, 2026; Meta Business Agent eligibility), MyOperator deployment data (262 agents, 91 businesses, 307,925 messages), and Indian BSP industry listings (Interakt, AiSensy, Wati, Gallabox). Rates and features change - always confirm on the official pages before spending.